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1 Urban Digital Memory: A tool to evaluate spatial interventions in public space - a study of Teatré Shahr Square, Tehran

Keywords (draft): Digital Memory, Right to the city, Social Media, Public Engagement, Digital Participation

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3 Introduction

The urban environments have always been transforming through different eras. The transformations caused by designers and planners have undergone a metamorphosis, starting from blueprints to co-design with citizens (Arnstein 2019; Horelli and Wallin 2024; Mueller et al. 2018). In the past few years, the social justice approaches amplified the concentration on engaging the public in urban interventions. However, not all countries have a democratic structure to do so.

In countries like Iran, despite following the theories and works of citizen engagement in academia, the practice is far behind this mindset. Many urban development projects are implemented with a top-down approach, regardless of the responsible party. Whether a contractor, developer, designer, planner, or policy maker, none ever approached the public for their opinions on an urban project. There are minimal practices that tried to include citizens within their work by running surveys or interviews. Nevertheless, the number of participators have barely met the satisfaction of the affected population, which looked more like being manipulated (Arnstein 2019). The planning and design approaches in countries with less democratic political systems would have the least amount of successful public engagement through their process.

Although active participation has never been an easy practice, there have been tools and platforms that made the process smoother for both ends. Living in the digital era, many citizens have access to online social platforms where they can usually speak up on their own, with the chance that their opinion could be heard nationally and even globally. In such an era, Iran is not an exception either. Although Iranians have filtered internet access, they use VPNs to bypass the restrictions and access the free internet, sharing their opinions, voices, cries, compliments, memories, and all other experiences unaccessible on online social networks.

This new accessibility can be considered as a shortcut to democracy. Sharing the news and posts regarding urban spaces is an ongoing phenomenon that is more than just a shared media with a caption. It can be seen as acknowledging a new space, or the opposite, downgrading a new intervention in the city. The background of a city can now be traced within the online platforms run by individuals who captured it throughout time. This doesn't end with the past of urban spaces, but also how an urban space changes in real-time, which would have its own responses. How citizens react to an urban project is evident on social media, and how they perceive the transformed urban space as before. The urban space is not just a physical or mental entity; it's also digital.

This study aims to tackle the matter of how citizens' lived experiences shared on social media form as urban digital memories. The digital memory creates newer concepts on top of the right to the city notion that can be called right to the memory. The project focuses on how the right to the memory can become a significant tool to validate urban interventions on spatial features through a digital public engagement and participation perspective.

4 Problem Statement

There are urban spaces, specifically, public spaces that hold a large pool of collective and individual memories within them, either tragic, joyful, or revolutionary (Solnit 2009). City Theater's Square[1] is not an exception. However, the public apparently doesn't have any right or authority over the space and the memories within it as common property. Some spaces get manipulated, transformed, or even demolished by government enforced by economic or political interests(Paccoud 2016). The example of it would be the Haussmannian boulevards that demolished the existing urban streets into wide and long boulevards with luxury retail shops on the sides and policing to oppress any opposition from citizens in the most dominance possible (Harvey 2006). The citizens don't have any agency over the space to make decisions, or at least to be informed clearly about the interventions or changes made by the actors on the higher ground. Not only with the actors, but also with the decision makers, this applies too. Right to the memory is a metaphor of collective/individual rights over space tied to memories that emerge within it. This represents a bond made between the space and its dwellings and visitors by memories, emotions, presence, and activities that shaped each person's lived-experience in that space. Nevertheless, this connection is taken for granted by the actors, designers, policy makers and governments holding the upper hand of power. Sometimes it's even ignored by them or does conflict with their main interests.

The memory is a valuable lived-experience that holds evidence of a lived, conceived and perceived physical space for each individual (Shaw and Graham 2017).

[1] Teatré Shahr in Persian [translated by the author]